

MWC and its lost charm

There was a time when the Mobile World Congress (MWC) was the beating heart of the consumer tech industry. Every tech journalist looked forward to attending it. Including me. And for obvious reasons.

For journalists, analysts, brands and enthusiasts alike, Barcelona in early spring was the place where the future of technology revealed itself. So much so that MWC kind of replaced CES as the biggest celebration of tech. It was where brands came to make statements, where executives laid out their ambitions for the year ahead, and where the industry's next big consumer trend often came into focus before it reached the mainstream.

For years, MWC served as the launchpad for some of the biggest names in consumer technology. Samsung, Huawei, Honor, One-Plus, Oppo – and many others – used the global stage to unveil flagship smartphones, foldables, connected devices and ambitious concepts that shaped conversations far beyond the show floor.

Beyond the booths and keynotes, what I always looked forward to at MWC were the conversations. The event was invaluable because it brought together decision-makers from across markets. It allowed media and industry watchers to meet global executives, understand regional priorities and get a clearer sense of where technology was headed. In many ways, MWC was as much about context as it was about hardware.

But somewhere along the way, that magic has faded. While I have realised that over the past two years, it actually hit hard this time.

Over the last few years, MWC has gradually lost the consumer-first energy that once defined it. The shift has been subtle, but unmistakable. It used to be this mass-market heavy innovation hub but has now become an enterprise-heavy conference dominated by telecom infrastructure, B2B solutions, AI-for-enterprise narratives, cloud discussions, private 5G, industrial use cases and corporate partnership announcements.

All of that has value. The telecom industry is the backbone of MWC and enterprise tech-



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nology deserves its moment. But for a conference that built much of its global cultural relevance on consumer anticipation, the balance now feels off. MWC 2026 was perhaps the clearest example yet of that decline.

For one of the world's biggest tech conferences, this year's edition felt unusually dull. In terms of global consumer-facing announcements, there was barely anything of real significance. The only major headline-grabbing launch of stature came from Xiaomi with the 17 series and notably, that happened a day before the event properly kicked off.

To be fair, many major consumer brands still showed up. The booths were there. The branding was there. The footfall was there. But the actual technology on display often felt familiar, even recycled. Much of what was being showcased seemed less like a glimpse into the future and more like a repackaging of concepts and products already seen at CES.

That is a problem. Because conferences like MWC do not survive on scale alone. They survive on relevance.

This year's geopolitical backdrop made things worse. The Iran-Israel conflict had a visible impact on participation and momentum, particularly for executives from the APAC region who were unable to travel. It reduced not just the volume of conversations, but also their quality. Of course, GSMA cannot control geopolitics. But it can control how resilient, compelling, and future-proof the event is in the face of such disruptions. That is where the real concern lies.

MWC is too important a brand to drift into redundancy. It still has enormous institutional value, deep legacy and unmatched convening power across telecom and mobile ecosystems. GSMA needs to take note and quickly. MWC needs to rediscover its balance.

It needs to become a stage where consumer innovation matters again, where flagship launches feel natural and where brands have a reason to save their biggest reveals for Barcelona. And where the world once again looks to the event not just for networking, but for direction. **d**